

Self-directed Conservation Field Placement

Nilo Nature Forest Reserve, East Usambara Mountains, Tanzania

Host: Friends of Nilo Forest (FONF), Swiss conservation association (in formation), Aesch ZH, Switzerland — niloforest.com
Location: Forest Base at the boundary of the Nilo Nature Forest Reserve, near Misalai, Amani Division, Muheza District, Tanga Region
Duration: 3 to 6 months (longer by arrangement)
Start: possible now; rolling intake
Places: 1–2 at a time
Contribution: USD 1,200 per month, full board (own room in the Forest Base, three meals, water, electricity, internet, laundry, local field partner). USD 40 per day for stays under one month. Travel, visa, insurance, research permit and transfers are the participant's responsibility.

The site

Nilo is a Nature Forest Reserve of about 6,025 ha, gazetted on 7 December 2007 under Tanzania's highest level of forest protection, the second largest forest block of the East Usambaras after Amani and part of the Eastern Arc Mountains. Records include c. 800 plant species with several *Saintpaulia* taxa, c. 100 bird species, the Usambara three-horned chameleon and the Angolan black-and-white colobus. Nilo Peak reaches 1,506 m. Rain falls in all months (1,200–2,200 mm). The reserve is the water catchment for more than 30,000 people in 17 villages. It is managed by the Tanzania Forest Service with limited enforcement capacity; illegal logging, poaching and encroachment are the main pressures. Compared with Amani, Nilo has almost no recent research or monitoring presence.

The placement

There is no existing programme. The placement is to build one. The participant designs and runs, with a local field partner, the first systematic monitoring of the reserve boundary zone. Expected building blocks, to be shaped by the participant's own proposal:

- Patrol routes along the boundary and into the reserve, recorded by GPS, with incident logging (cut stumps, snares, charcoal pits, encroachment)
- Recruiting and training two village forest monitors from neighbouring villages, and a simple reporting routine for them
- Baseline species records (camera traps, transects, acoustic recording, herpetology surveys, depending on skills and equipment brought)
- A field protocol and data structure that the next participant can take over
- Working-level contact with the Tanzania Forest Service ranger post in Amani; the participant does not negotiate agreements with authorities

Data belong to the participant for academic use, with a copy to FONF. Thesis projects (BSc/MSc) are welcome; supervision must come from the home institution.

What is provided

- Accommodation in the Forest Base, a simple house next to the main lodge building, own room
- Full board prepared by lodge staff
- Saidi, local guide and site manager, as daily field partner (Swahili, basic English)

- Internet (mobile broadband, c. 20 Mbps), grid electricity with solar backup, 4×4 transport to Muheza by arrangement
- Direct access to the reserve boundary on foot from the house

Conditions

- Remote site: 1 h 45 min of rough track from the tarmac road, no shops, nearest medical care in Muheza. Humid climate, steep terrain, 4–6 h walking on field days.
- Minimum age 21, physically fit, basic English required, Swahili an advantage, prior fieldwork abroad an advantage.
- Application with a one-page project sketch: what you would build in your time here and how.
- Two-week trial period; the remaining contribution is refunded if either side ends the placement then.

Accommodation and contribution

Forest Base (placement students), per month, full board	
Single occupancy	USD 1,200
With companion (no work obligation, no data rights)	USD 1,800
Main building (relatives, supervisors, groups), per month, full board	
Single occupancy	USD 1,800
Double occupancy	USD 2,400
Three persons, third on the sofa bed	USD 3,000

Included: own room, three meals, water, electricity, internet, laundry, field partner. Not included: travel, visa, insurance, research permit (COSTECH) and Tanzania Forest Service fees, transfers. The accommodation is the Nilo Forest Lodge; regular rates at niloforestlodge.com.

Contact

Ralf Degenhardt, Founder, Friends of Nilo Forest — ralf@niloforest.com — +41 79 681 21 06 — niloforest.com/field-placement

Friends of Nilo Forest, association in formation, Chilegässli 12A, 8904 Aesch ZH, Switzerland. Version September 2026.